Travel ing overnight in a combination of district buses, I reached Rameswaram only the next day. During this time, I did my best to free myself from the very past which appeared to have come to an end with Jal aluddin. But the moment I reached my house, grief assailed me afresh. I had no words for Zohara or for my niece Mehboob, both of whom were crying uncontrol ably. I had no tears to shed. We sorrowful y put Jal aluddin's body to rest.

My father held my hands for a long time. There were no tears in his eyes either. "Do you not see, Abul, how the Lord lengthens the shadows? Had it been His wil , He could have made them constant. But He makes the sun their guide, little by little He shortens them. It is He who has made the night a mantle for you, and sleep a rest. Jal aluddin has gone into a long sleep—a dreamless sleep, a complete rest of al his being within simple unconsciousness. Nothing wil befal us except what Al ah has ordained. He is our Guardian. In Al ah, my son, put your trust." He slowly closed his wrinkled eyelids and went into a trance-like state.

Death has never frightened me. After al , everyone has to go one day. But perhaps Jal aluddin went a little too early, a little too soon. I could not bring myself to stay for